50TH ANNIVERSARY
1985-1995

| GLOBAL EYE |

LIGHT IN THE DARK

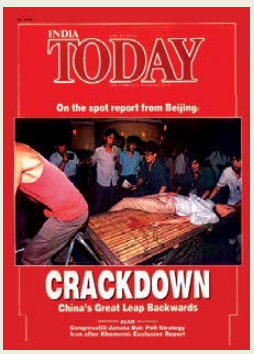
The end of apartheid in South Africa and fall of the Soviet Union were bright spots even as China crushed a rebellion and wars raged in Sri Lanka and the Gulf



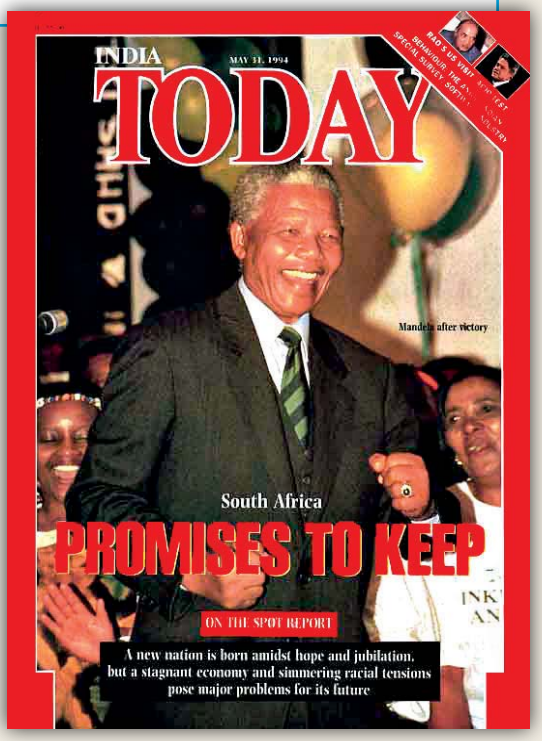
▲ Dec. 15, 1986



▲ Sep. 15, 1988



▲ Jun. 30, 1989

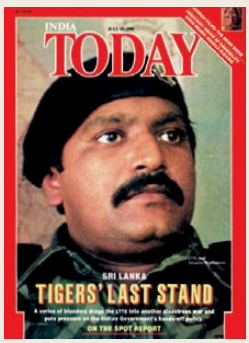


▲ May 31, 1994

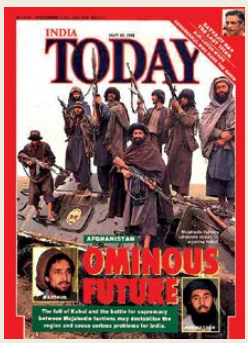
In **the intervening decade** of 1985-1995, South Asia's immediate neighbourhood was among the most volatile. Pakistan and Sri Lanka were in flux, one under a dictatorship, the other ravaged by an internecine war over a Tamil homeland. In Lanka, an India-brokered peace between the government and the V. Prabhakaran-led Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) collapsed and we were dragged into the conflict, eventually paying a heavy price for the interference, both with the lives of our soldiers and of a former prime minister, Rajiv Gandhi.

In Pakistan, the unexpected death of dictator Gen. Zia-ul-Haq in a plane crash in 1988 led to another democracy reset, with Benazir Bhutto now in the high chair. Further northwest, the fall of the Soviet-backed Najibullah government in 1992 ushered in factional warfare among the mujahideen groups that had been ranged against him. The country soon drifted into violent anarchy. In West Asia, in the 1991 Gulf War, a ground operation by the US against former client-state Iraq got Saddam Hussein to vacate his invasion of Kuwait and open up for arms inspections.

Meanwhile, history bent in a different direction in Africa. In 1994, Nelson Mandela took oath as South Africa's first democratically elected Black leader. The end of apartheid stood out as one of the era's rare, peaceful moral victories. ■



▲ Jul. 15, 1990



▲ May 15, 1992



▲ Jan. 31, 1991



▲ Sep. 15, 1991